DERECH HASHEM: THE RAMHAL'S WAY OF GOD, AT TIFERET EYAL

Do Non-Jews Have a Share in the World to Come?

Derech Hashem 2:4:6-8

Sefer: Derech Hashem by Rabbi Moshe Hayim Luzzatto (the Ramhal) **Section:** Part 2, Chapter 4, paragraphs 6-8 **Shiur:** Part of Dayan Daniel Kada's Derech Hashem series at Tiferet Eyal, Thursday 1 July 2021

These notes are based on an automatic transcript of the recording.

Review: the root, the branches and the missed chance

The Rabbi reviewed the argument of the chapter so far. Because of Adam's sin humanity fell to a lower state, but kept the potential to rise. Hashem gave a period of roots, roughly the first two thousand years, in which a person could become the root of refined descendants. Only Avraham met the challenge, despite righteous people like Metushelah and Hanokh. At the tower of Bavel the rest of humanity was divided into seventy nations. Individuals may still come off their tree and be grafted onto Avraham's, which is conversion. Avraham's tree has 600,000 main branches, and every Jew is a leaf on one of them. And the nations were given one more chance at Matan Torah to redefine their roots, which they declined.

He added that he would explain at the end of the chapter how the Rambam's approach differs from the Ramhal's.

Har Sinai and sinah

The Gemara plays on the name Har Sinai: from there sinah, hatred, came down to the nations. The Rabbi explained it with the image of someone who just missed the train. He had the chance, did not jump on, and will be jealous for the rest of his life of the one who did. The nations recognised they had missed their opportunity, and there is no going back.

He suggested that much antisemitism is simply ignorance, but at its root lies a recognition that the Jewish people have a distinct role and have shaped human civilisation and history, and a resentment of that.

Paragraph 6: the nations have a neshamah

"Veulam..." Despite missing the opportunity twice, the nations were not decreed to be destroyed. They remain on the level of humanity after Adam's sin. And since they have an element of humanity, even on a lower level than Israel, Hashem wanted them to have a taste of the true life of Israel. "Vehayinu sheyesh lahem neshamah": they have a soul. It is not on the same level as a Jewish soul, but it is a soul. And they have misvot through which they can

achieve success: the seven Noahide laws. All this, the Ramhal adds, was prepared in advance and activated when needed.

The Rabbi called this an important line, because children are sometimes brought up, wrongly, to think that the world exists only for the Jewish people. "Okay, so why on earth are all these billions of Chinese people around?" The answer is that they have their own purpose and role. It may be a different role, "but they still have a neshamah. They're not animals." The seven Noahide laws are the basis of human civilisation. "No one's here to serve each other... It's all of humanity, and Jewish people have a special role to play."

A participant recalled a teaching that in the future the Jewish people will dine while the nations serve. The Rabbi said that refers to the days of Mashiah, and its meaning is shibud malkhuyot: political sovereignty, so that Israel no longer answers to others. "Doesn't mean that they are there to bring us tea."

Paragraph 7: one nation in the World to Come

"Veulam laolam haba lo timasena umot zulat Yisrael." In the World to Come proper, after Mashiah (not Gan Eden), there will be only one national identity, Israel. The righteous of the nations who merit it will exist there as an appendage to Israel, like clothing (levush) to a person.

Who are the righteous of the nations? Those who keep the seven Noahide laws. The Rabbi noted that the Rambam (Hilchot Melakhim, based on the Gemara) adds a condition: they must keep them out of recognition that they are commanded by God, not merely because they think this is a good way to live. A participant found that troubling, since many decent people would be excluded. The Rabbi explained that this follows from the Rambam's philosophy, in which the World to Come is an intellectual connection with the Divine. If someone never connected his good life to God, how can he have a connection with God afterwards?

The Rambam's very different approach

The Rabbi then contrasted the two views: - **The Ramhal**, which he called definitely the mainstream opinion: a non-Jew who keeps the Noahide laws is not damned, but limited. However good he is, he remains "around the stadium," maybe in the top back seats, or listening from outside. In the World to Come he is a levush, an appendage. - **The Rambam**: none of this intrinsic difference appears. Jews and non-Jews alike can reach an extremely high connection with the Almighty. The Jew has a greater propensity because his life is governed by the 613 misvot, which make it easier to refine himself, but it is not intrinsic to being Jewish. The Rambam even wrote that Aristotle reached almost the level of prophecy. "It's all about your mind... Human beings are human beings, full stop."

A participant asked whether having 613 misvot just gives Jews more ways to fail. The Rabbi rejected this firmly: "You're seeing the misvot as ways to make you fail. That's a very wrong understanding." More misvot mean more opportunity to refine yourself. "God doesn't set us up for failure. He's setting us up for success."

On antisemitism, a participant suggested it reminds us that we are different. The Rabbi agreed that it can act as a check on how we behave, and said that if Jews always acted beyond the letter of the law, antisemitism would be much lower.

Paragraph 8: three levels of hashgahah

The Ramhal now explains how Hashem oversees the nations. Recall the general hashgahah (hashgahah kelalit) over animals, learned before Pesah: Hashem looks at the species, not the individual animal. With the nations, He appoints an angelic officer, a sar, over each nation, who oversees its affairs in detail. Only Israel receives His direct, personal hashgahah.

The Rabbi illustrated with a CEO: - **Animals** are like the office pens. "I need a hundred pens here, I don't care which ones, as long as they work." - **The nations** are like an employee the CEO does not oversee himself; he tells his secretary to make sure that person is doing a good job. Nothing goes unnoticed, but the connection is less intimate. - **Israel** is the important worker the CEO oversees directly: "I'm looking at you."

The chapter will be finished on Monday.

Summary

- The nations, having missed the chance at Sinai, remain on the level of humanity after Adam's sin; the Gemara links Har Sinai with sinah.
- Paragraph 6: non-Jews have a neshamah and a real role through the seven Noahide laws; the world is not only for the Jews.
- Paragraph 7: in the World to Come there is one nation, Israel, and the righteous of the nations are attached to it as a garment.
- The Rambam differs: any person can reach a high connection with Hashem; Jews have more misvot, which means more opportunity, not more risk.
- Paragraph 8: animals receive general hashgahah, nations are overseen through an appointed sar, and Israel receives direct personal hashgahah.

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